

tracker-credentials

Tracker Credentials — Env Vars vs Cookies Files

Revision: 2 **Last modified:** 2026-08-18T00:00:00Z **Audience:** Operators configuring tracker access on a fresh boba host or refreshing an expired session. **Authority:** Operator mandate 2026-08-15 (canonical file naming + ~/Downloads default + env-vars-AND-cookies-files support).

The two mechanisms

Boba consumes tracker credentials via **exactly two** channels — and both are respected together:

#	Mechanism	Kind	Precedence	Refreshed by
1	.env env vars	<TRACKER>_USERNAME / <TRACKER>_PASSWORD / <TRACKER>_COOKIES	Whatever is present at container-start time.	Manual edit (or the loader for _COOKIES).
2	~/Downloads/cookies_<tracker>.txt	Browser Netscape TSV	The loader auto-writes into .env, so cookies-file wins for _COOKIES — every restart re-	Re-export from browser + restart / boba-svc up.

#	Mechanism	Kind	Precedence	Refreshed by
			parses the file.	

The **loader** scripts/load-tracker-cookies.sh is the bridge: it turns the file into the env var, atomically, with §11.4.10.A leak-audit + §11.4.10 value-never-logged discipline. See its [dedicated guide](#).

Per-tracker matrix

Tracker	Auth style	Env vars	Cookies file (recommended)	Load-bearing session cookie
RuTracker	Login form → session cookie	RUTRACKER_USERNAME RUTRACKER_PASSWORD RUTRACKER_COOKIES	~/Downloads/ cookies_rutracker.txt	bb_session=
NNM-Club	Cookie-only (form auth flaky)	NNMCLUB_USERNAME NNMCLUB_PASSWORD NNMCLUB_COOKIES	~/Downloads/ cookies_nnmclub.txt	phpbb2mysql_4_
RuTor	Public (no login)	RUTOR_USERNAME RUTOR_PASSWORD (present for parity, unused)	~/Downloads/ cookies_rutor.txt (optional)	<i>n/a</i>
Kinozal	Login form → session cookie	KINOZAL_USERNAME KINOZAL_PASSWORD	~/Downloads/ cookies_kinozal.txt (optional)	uid= + pass=
IPorrents	Login form → session cookie	IPTORRENTS_USERNAME IPTORRENTS_PASSWORD IPTORRENTS_COOKIES	~/Downloads/ cookies_iporrents.txt	pass= (required canary; uid= is low-entropy identifier, present alongside it)

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Jackett-fronted trackers	API-key	JACKETT_API_KEY (extracted by autoconfig)	<i>n/a</i>	<i>n/a</i>

Rule of thumb: if a tracker needs a session token AND your browser can log into it fine, use the cookies file — refreshing is one browser re-export away. If you have programmatic credentials and no CAPTCHA / MFA, env-vars are simpler.

Step-by-step — export cookies from your browser

Firefox (recommended — most reliable Netscape export)

1. Install the **Cookie Quick Manager** add-on: <https://addons.mozilla.org/en-US/firefox/addon/cookie-quick-manager/>
2. Log into the tracker's website in a normal browser window (solve any CAPTCHA, tick *Remember me*, verify you land on your profile).
3. Click the add-on icon → **Manage all cookies** → search the tracker's domain (rutracker.org, nmclub.to, rutor.is, kinozal.guru, iptorrents.com) → **Export** → **Netscape HTTP Cookie File**.
4. Save as **exactly** `cookies_<tracker>.txt` in your host's `~/Downloads/` folder — the loader's convention is:

```
${TRACKER_COOKIE_DIR:-$HOME/Downloads}/cookies_<tracker>.txt
```

with `<tracker>` **lowercase** (rutracker, nmclub, rutor, kinozal, iptorrents).

5. Trigger a reload:

```
bash scripts/load-tracker-cookies.sh           # writes
      into .env
bash scripts/boba-svc.sh restart
      # containers pick it up
```

Chrome / Chromium / Brave / Edge

1. Install **Get cookies.txt LOCALLY** extension: <https://chromewebstore.google.com/detail/get-cookiectxt-locally/cclclndahbckbenkjhflpdbgdldlbecc>
2. Log into the tracker.
3. Open extension → *Export As* → **Netscape** → save to ~/Downloads/cookies_<tracker>.txt.
4. Same reload commands as above.

Command-line (curl-style) — advanced

If you already have a cookies.txt from a curl -c login flow you scripted yourself, simply rename it to match the convention and drop it in ~/Downloads/. The format is standard Netscape TSV — the loader is oblivious to how the file was produced, only to its schema and the tracker-name it's addressed to.

Verifying it worked

The definitive test:

```
bash challenges/scripts/credentials_wired_challenge.sh
```

Expected shape (verified 2026-08-18):

```
PASS: .env mode = 0600
PASS: .env matched by .gitignore
PASS: .env is not tracked in git
PASS: all 11 required credential var NAMES present in .env
PASS: NNMCLUB_COOKIES contains phpbb2mysql_4_sid= (session cookie present)
PASS: RUTRACKER_COOKIES contains bb_session= (RuTracker session cookie present)
PASS: RUTOR_COOKIES shape OK (public tracker; cf_clearance helps Cloudflare)
PASS: KINOZAL_COOKIES contains uid= or pass= (Kinozal session cookie present)
PASS: IPTORRENTS_COOKIES contains uid= or pass= (IPTorrents session cookie present)
PASS: all 11 credential vars propagated to qbittorrent-proxy container env (non-empty)
PASS: scripts/load-tracker-cookies.sh exists + executable + bash -n clean
PASS: scripts/load-tracker-cookies.sh --dry-run exit 0
PASS: scripts/load-tracker-cookies.sh --dry-run emits the standard
```

```
summary line
PASS: cookies_rutracker.txt present in /home/milosvasic/Downloads
AND recognised by loader
PASS: cookies_nnmclub.txt present in /home/milosvasic/Downloads
AND recognised by loader
PASS: cookies_rutor.txt present in /home/milosvasic/Downloads
AND recognised by loader
PASS: cookies_kinozal.txt present in /home/milosvasic/Downloads
AND recognised by loader
PASS: cookies_ip torrents.txt present in /home/milosvasic/Downloads
AND recognised by loader
Total: PASS=18 FAIL=0
```

Any FAIL names the offending file / var / substring.

Precedence & lifecycle

1. **~/Downloads/cookies_<tracker>.txt exists and matches .env's value.** Loader marks UNCHANGED (idempotent), no I/O.
2. **File exists and DIFFERS from .env.** Loader §11.4.10.A-audits the new values (aborts if leaked), then atomically overwrites the <TRACKER>_COOKIES line in .env. Containers pick it up on the next up / restart.
3. **File exists but the session cookie is missing.** Loader reports PARSE – was not exported from a logged-in session and skips that tracker; the existing .env value is kept.
4. **File absent.** Loader reports SKIP. If .env still holds a working <TRACKER>_COOKIES= from an earlier run, containers continue to use it — the env var is the durable state, the file is just the on-ramp.
5. **.env has env-vars but no cookies file.** Nothing to load; containers use whatever .env provides. This is the fresh-install baseline.

Precedence at container-start time is always: .env wins, because the container never reads ~/Downloads directly. The loader's whole job is to keep .env in sync with whatever cookies-file exists.

Security — what boba does NOT do

- **Cookie values NEVER appear in logs.** Every status line prints tracker name, cookie NAMES, counts, mtime — never a value.
- **.env is mode 0600 and gitignored.** The atomic writer enforces both.

- **~/Downloads/cookies_*.txt are NEVER committed.** They live on the operator's host filesystem, outside the repo. The loader NEVER git adds them.
 - **§11.4.10.A pre-store leak audit** runs on every non-empty cookie value ≥ 8 chars before writing — if the value already appears in the working tree or the last 1000 commits, the store is BLOCKED and the operator is instructed to rotate the cookie in the browser (invalidate the session server-side, re-login, re-export).
 - **RuTor is a public tracker.** Its cookie file, if present, is loaded solely for cf_clearance (Cloudflare) usefulness — no session token is ever needed.
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Related documentation

- [docs/scripts/load-tracker-cookies.md](#) — the loader's full script-level reference.
- [docs/scripts/extract-tracker-cookies.md](#) — the single-tracker extraction primitive the loader delegates to.
- [docs/TOKENS_AND_KEYS.md](#) — the master env-vars reference for every credential category (trackers, metadata, scanners, observability).
- [docs/FAQ.md](#) — cookie-refresh FAQs.
- [CLAUDE.md](#) — project-wide env-var + credentials policy (§11.4.10 handling, freeleech-only, WebUI defaults).
- [challenges/scripts/credentials_wired_challenge.sh](#) — the standing RED/GREEN guard.